wanted to imprint his own style of play at the club.

However, time was a constraint, the first game just three weeks away. Besides, the lack of match practice meant that their first real test was against East Bengal in their drawn opener. But the players responded well to the tweaks and changes Miranda implemented, remaining unbeaten for the rest of the tournament. "I could have continued with the way things were under Gombau. But in case I failed, I didn't want to regret the fact that I hadn't implemented my methodology," says Miranda.

These days, Miranda is back in Goa spending time with family. The team will regroup towards the end of July for preseason, as they gear up for their debut in Asian competition, besides the ISL and other domestic cups.

"The respect and appreciation of the players is more important for me than winning the Super Cup or qualifying for the AFC Cup. It validates my belief that I'm on the right track," adds Miranda.

Odisha's Super Cup success was the first major trophy earned by an Indian coach at the helm of an ISL club. Since the league was established in 2013, the only other Indian to have led an ISL side is Khalid Jamil, who worked with NorthEast United FC in 2021-22. "The hope is that more Indian coaches can guide teams in the near future. The new generation is so much better than some of the foreigners who come here. I hope they can be trusted by the owners to take on this responsibility," says Miranda. ■

Shail Desai

SONG OF ICE AND GRIT

Defying challenges, the Indian women's ice hockey team is making its mark on the global stage

The opening match of the Ice Hockey Women's Asia and Oceania Championship in April left the Indian national team devastated. They had taken the lead as early as the fourth minute, but at the final buzzer, Iran thumped them 17-1.

The players were aware of what it had taken to just make it to the tournament in Thailand. They went back to the drawing board, regrouped and came back to win their next two group encounters against Kyrgyzstan (3-0) and Kuwait (6-0). It helped them qualify for the quarterfinal where their winning run continued, edging past Malaysia 3-2.



FACEBOOK ICE HOCKEY FAMILY

And though they lost the semi-final to Thailand (0-13) and the third place match to Singapore (1-3), they knew they had redeemed their campaign to finish on a high.

"We were shattered yet frustrated after the Iran match because we knew our potential. The team discussed all the things we had worked on and it clicked for us there on," says Diskit Angmo, who was awarded the Most Valuable Player of the tournament.

Ice hockey continues to be a seasonal affair in India, played only through the winter months

It was a sign of the mental fortitude the team has developed while chasing ice hockey against all odds. The sport continues to be a seasonal affair, played only through the winter months due to a lack of infrastructure. Angmo recalls how they struggled to find players during their first international tournament in 2016. In fact, the local championship that year in Ladakh had just three women's teams. "The number of girls who have taken to the sport has jumped and we had 10 teams this year. In fact, there was competition even to get on the national team—to have five new faces is massive," says Angmo.

Most of the players still come from Ladakh, though the Ice Hockey Association of India (IHAI) has made efforts to take the sport to other regions as well. "We organised the national championship in Gulmarg in 2021 and Kaza last year. It's how we managed to scout two girls from Himachal Pradesh who represented India," says Harjinder Singh, general secretary of IHAI.

A handful of players were picked from the national championship in February. For a month before the tournament, they were part of a conditioning camp in Leh led by Bharat Singh. Head coach Darrin Harrold monitored their progress from his base in Canada through his deputies, Tsewang Gyaltson and Amit Belwal, before joining the team in Thailand.

Funding, however, remains a challenge. "They are coming up with a policy for sports such as ice hockey that are not registered under the Sports Authority of India. We hope to get some support from the government through it," says Singh. ■

Shail Desai